

NEWS RELEASE

For Immediate Release
April 16, 2025

Media Contact: Mary Frances Forcier, Deputy Public Affairs and Communications Officer
571-439-6917, MaryFrances.Forcier@loudoun.gov

Environmental Commission Honors 2025 Environmental Excellence Award Winners

The Loudoun County Environmental Commission has announced the winners of its annual Environmental Excellence Awards, which honor individuals, businesses, nonprofit organizations and educators for their leadership on environmental issues. The awards were presented during the Board of Supervisors' April 15, 2025, meeting.

The 2025 winners and categories are:

- **Citizen or Community Group: What About the Turtles?** The group, led by Tanya Finch, is dedicated to protecting wildlife impacted by construction. The group mobilized community volunteers and coordinated with a local construction company and a wildlife advocacy group on a rescue operation for box turtles trapped in a construction site.
- **Educator: Beth Sastre, Virginia Cooperative Extension – Loudoun Commercial Horticulturalist.** Sastre provided bilingual training on worker protection standards to local growers and agricultural workers using an innovative outreach system for hard-to-reach groups. In 2024, she conducted training for 147 workers in 30 vineyards, supporting a year with no health incidents or pesticide spills.
- **Government Employee or Program/Team: Loudoun Water.** Loudoun Water partnered with NOVA Parks to create Reservoir Park along the shores of Beaverdam Reservoir. The innovative park model combines the reservoir's primary purpose of providing clean drinking water with benefits of open space, recreation, and public awareness.
- **Lifetime Achievement: Phil Daley.** Daley has been involved in local environmental education, protection and advocacy efforts since 1980. He has volunteered with many organizations, including the Audubon Naturalist Society, Banshee Reeks Nature Preserve, Goose Creek Scenic River Advisory Committee and the Loudoun Wildlife Conservancy. He has a long history of engaging with the community to increase environmental awareness.
- **Lifetime Achievement: Al Van Huyck.** Van Huyck is a longtime advocate for environmental conservation in Loudoun. Through his work on the county's Planning Commission and Agricultural District Review Committee, Van Huyck has helped to shape county policies on agriculture, historic sites and natural resources. He has also helped found the Loudoun Preservation and Conservation Coalition and Friends of Blue Ridge Mountains and recently launched the Loudoun Cemetery Conservancy.

- **Student: Ryan Nisay, Potomac Falls High School senior.** Nisay founded the Loudoun Nature Conservation Project, which encourages young people to take action in environmental restoration. The organization has partnerships with 14 schools, parks and community organizations.

This is the third year of the [Environmental Excellence Awards](#) program created by the [Environmental Commission](#), which advises the Board of Supervisors and makes recommendations on policies and practices related to the environment, sustainability and energy management. Members of the commission include representatives from the community, industry and higher education.

Upcoming Energy & Environment Forum May 22

The Environmental Commission is holding its third annual Energy and Environment Forum Thursday, May 22, 2025, 5:30 – 8:00 p.m., at the Academies of Loudoun, 42075 Loudoun Academy Drive, Leesburg. More information is online at loudoun.gov/EnvironmentalForum.

Stay Informed

Anyone interested in energy and environmental news from the Loudoun County government may subscribe to the Environment & Energy category available from the [Notify Me/News Flash](#) section of the Loudoun County website. Subscribers can choose to receive email and/or text updates, news releases and other information of interest to residents and businesses regarding environmental topics.

More Information

More information about the county's efforts to increase environmental sustainability and resilience for Loudoun residents and businesses is online at loudoun.gov/environment.



Members of the Loudoun County Board of Supervisors with winners of the Loudoun Environmental Commission's 2025 Environmental Excellence Awards